

Dead in the Water — GM Guide

The runbook. Sit this next to you during the game. It assumes you've already read the Story Bible and Clue Deck. This document is the choreography.

Total runtime

Phase	Length	What happens
Pre-game setup	90 min before guests	Hide clues, prep props
Arrival / framing	15 min	Cocktail-hour Sinner briefing, fiction frame
Phase 1 — Discovery	15 min	The body, character sheets, Last Night doc
Phase 2 — First Suspicions	30 min	Hank surfaces, the cleat returns
Phase 3 — Investigation	40 min	Five Sinners confess
Phase 4 — Unmasking	30 min	Cody's photo, Sebastian breaks
Phase 5 — Architect	15 min	The Christmas story, Vivi breaks
Closing toast	10 min	Out-of-character wrap, photos
Total	~2h 45m	Plus food breaks if needed

Pre-game setup checklist

90 minutes before guests arrive

Clue placement. Hide all 24 clues per the locations in the Clue Deck. Walk the house with the Clue Deck printed and a Sharpie — check each one off as you place it. The trickiest ones to remember:

- Clue 2-2 (green tweed scrap) goes into Hank's coat in the entryway closet. You'll need to do this *after* Daniel hangs his coat. Plan to grab a moment alone.
- Clue 3-1 (burned manuscript page) needs to look like it survived the bonfire. Singe the edges with a lighter over the sink, then drop into the cooled fire pit ash before guests arrive.
- Clue 4-1 (the notarized envelope) goes into the inside pocket of Sebastian's blazer. He'll be wearing it when he arrives. Plan: ask Jaymon to hang the blazer in the coat closet "to keep it from getting smoky at the bonfire." Plant the envelope then.

Props to prepare in advance.

- Solomon the parrot — stuffed bird or printed silhouette on a perch. Keep him in the gazebo until Phase 2.
- A clipboard with the printed Saturday schedule (Alexander's prop).
- A ring of keys you can jangle.

- A “ALEXANDER · HOUSE MANAGER” name tag.
- The full GM packet: Story Bible (you only), Clue Deck (you only), this Guide (you only), Last Night doc (player copies), character sheets (player copies in named envelopes), accusation ballot slips.
- The Cody photo. Print a paper that says “**\$60M → TURD (final)**” in handwriting (use a Sharpie). Photograph it on Ben’s phone 15 minutes before Phase 1 starts — that way the timestamp is recent but believable. Tell Ben “this is your hero clue, do not show this until I look at you in Phase 4.”

Recordings (optional but recommended for the Phase 5 reveal).

Record Sophia, in advance, telling her Broadway story twice — once as “Christmas dinner” and once as “Saturday night bonfire.” Play them back-to-back in Phase 5. If you don’t have time, narrate the detail instead per the Clue Deck note. *Either works.*

The Cody photo backup. If Ben loses his phone, gets nervous, or the photo doesn’t take cleanly, have a printed backup of the “\$60M → TURD (final)” paper in your clipboard. You can hand it to him in Phase 4 instead.

Locked rooms. Per Clue Deck. You can actually lock doors or just enforce a “Mr. Whitfield asked me to keep that closed” line. Locking is more fun if you’ve got the keys.

Arrival and framing (15 min before Phase 1)

The fiction starts the moment they walk in.

Greet each guest as Alexander, the house manager. You are *not* Alex. Stay in character. Hand each guest their named envelope. Inside: their character sheet, their copy of the Last Night doc, and their search permit for Phase 1 (which says: *Living room only*).

Read aloud to the group, once everyone is seated:

“Good morning. As most of you know, my name is Alexander. I’ve been the house manager here at the Whitfield lake house for four years now. I’d like to begin by saying I am so sorry. I found Mr. Crookshank in the shallows by the dock at 7:42 this morning. Dr. Langford has confirmed he passed sometime between 11:30 last night and midnight. The Sheriff’s Office is on their way — but Detective Reyes is en route from Olympia and won’t be here for several hours. In the meantime, I’d like to ask each of you to please read what’s in your envelope, privately, and then we’ll begin.”

Then say, more quietly:

“You may lie about anything in your envelope. You may keep secrets about anything in your envelope. The truth comes out only when the game makes it come out. If at any point you’re not sure what your character would do — ask me.”

Give them five minutes to read in silence. Then begin Phase 1.

Phase 1 — The Discovery (15 min)

You read all four GM auto-reveals from the Clue Deck. Slow. Theatrical. Let “Dick is dead” land with a straight face.

After the fourth auto-reveal (Solomon), bring out the parrot. Set him in the center of the coffee table. Say: *“He has been... vocal.”* Then have Solomon scream **“WHERE’S MY ROOT BEER!”** at maximum volume.

Phase 1 has no searching. The point is for everyone to read their sheets, look around the room at each other, and begin sizing each other up. Let it breathe. If the silence gets uncomfortable, deploy Solomon again.

End of Phase 1 cue: When you sense everyone has read everything they need to, you say:

“At my discretion, you’re now free to move about the house. I’ll let you know which rooms are open. Phase 2 begins in five minutes. Use that time to talk among yourselves and decide where you’d like to look first.”

Hand out the Phase 2 search permits.

Phase 2 — First Suspicions (30 min)

Structure: 10 min search round → 10 min discussion → 5 min second search → 5 min final discussion.

Your job during search rounds.

- Wander. Look at clipboard. Don’t lead anyone to anything.
- If somebody is two feet away from a clue and clearly missing it, you can casually say *“the light in here is funny, isn’t it”* or *“the cookbooks are really overdue for a dust.”* Use sparingly.
- If somebody tries to enter a locked room, intervene: *“Mr. Whitfield asked me to keep that closed for the morning. I apologize.”*
- If somebody asks you a direct question about a clue, you answer in character: *“I haven’t seen that before in my life.”*

Your job during discussion rounds.

- Enforce the mandatory share. Go around the room. Each player must share **one** clue they found this round. They choose which one.

- If a player says *“I didn’t find anything,”* press once: *“Not a single thing?”* If they hold, move on but make a mental note. You may bring Solomon back for a screech to remind them how this works.
- Take notes on who is sharing what. You’ll need to know who’s hoarding for Phase 5.

Solomon’s First Outburst — mid-discussion. Bring Solomon from the gazebo into the living room. Hold him. Make him squawk:

“WHERE’S MY ROOT BEER!”

Pause. Drop your voice into a lower register and have Solomon mutter:

“Don’t... don’t you talk about her like that...”

That second line is Hank’s, from the gazebo at 8 PM. The room’s eyes will turn to Daniel. Let it land. Do not say anything. Let Daniel sweat.

The Cleat — end of Phase 2 discussion.

“Levi was good enough to dive for it this morning. The cleat was eight feet down, twelve feet off the dock. There’s dried blood on the underside. Dr. Langford is comparing it to the wound.”

Hank’s confession. Triggered by either Solomon’s mutter, the green tweed scrap (Clue 2-2), or both. If Daniel doesn’t volunteer the confession, you can prompt: *“Hank. Solomon doesn’t say things he didn’t hear. Anything you’d like to share with the family?”* Daniel reads or paraphrases his confession script from the Clue Deck.

Final mandatory share. Then transition to Phase 3.

Phase 3 — The Investigation (40 min)

Structure: 15 min search round → 10 min discussion → 10 min second search → 5 min final discussion.

Bedrooms now unlock, including Richard’s guest room. The primary suite stays locked.

This phase is the workhorse. Five Sinner confessions land here. The room is going to be loud, fast, and full of false leads. Your job is to keep the pacing.

Confession order in Phase 3 (rough):

1. **Catherine** — after the burned manuscript page (Clue 3-1) is found.
2. **Eden** — after the thank-you note (Clue 3-2) surfaces. **Surface confession only.** She admits going to thank Richard for the book. She does *not* yet reveal she saw the TURD paper. If Emma jumps the gun and reveals everything in Phase 3, gently redirect: *“You said you went to thank him. Was there anything else?”* and if she still volunteers TURD, let her — but it weakens Cody’s moment. Better to coach Emma ahead of time.

3. **Bella** — after the guestbook page (Clue 3-6).
4. **Levi** — after the boarding ticket (Clue 3-7). Make sure Luke clarifies *chips, not money* at least three times. Comedy beat.
5. **Beau** — after the empty bottle (Clue 3-5) and the case (Clue 3-9). Solomon screeches **“WHERE’S MY ROOT BEER!”** on cue. Whole table laughs.

Pacing trick. If two confessions need to happen in the same discussion round, space them. Confession → reaction → questions → next clue → next confession. Don’t let them collapse into each other.

The dock diagram (Clue 3-8) is the big shift. When somebody peels the orca mural forward and finds the diagram, the room realizes this was *planned*. The Hawthornes will start to sweat. Watch Jaymon and Sophia’s body language. Note who tries to suppress it. This information is critical for Phase 5.

Alexander’s Photo Timeline — end of Phase 3. Hand the family the time-stamped photos. The 11:35 bonfire photo shows everyone *except* Sebastian. Then you ask, gently:

“Sebastian — where were you in this photo?”

Jaymon will say: *“On the deck. Smoke break. I told everyone.”* Hold the silence. Let the room sit in it. Then transition to Phase 4.

Phase 4 — The Unmasking (30 min)

Structure: 10 min search round → 10 min discussion (with Cody’s hero turn) → 5 min accusation vote → 5 min reveal.

The primary suite unlocks. Tell the family:

“The case has stalled. You can search anywhere now. Anywhere.”

Watch where people go. Jaymon will want to get to his blazer if he hasn’t already realized it’s the problem. Don’t let him remove anything — if he tries, intervene: *“I’d ask you to keep your hands away from anything you didn’t bring with you this weekend.”*

Cody’s hero turn — the choreography.

Wait for two specific things to surface first:

- The notarized envelope and the TURD will (Clue 4-1).
- The opera binoculars on the balcony (Clue 4-3).

Once both are on the table, the room is reeling. The motive is now visible — someone killed Richard to keep the inheritance from going to TURD. The room will be debating who.

That’s when you turn to Cody. Make a small show of it. Look around the room first. Let your eyes settle on Ben. Soften your voice:

“Cody. You’ve been very quiet this morning. Is there anything you’ve been holding onto? It’s okay if you do.”

Ben pulls out his phone. Shows the photo. Says his line:

“I went into his room Saturday afternoon. I just wanted to see what was in the leather thing. There was a paper. I took a picture. I didn’t know what TURD was. I didn’t tell anyone. I’m sorry. Here.”

The room loses its mind.

Eden’s corroboration — immediately after. Emma steps forward. She says her Phase 4 line:

“I saw it too. At nine, in his room. I’m sorry. He told me Friday he was leaving something to my grandparents. I went to verify. He had lied to me. I couldn’t bring myself to admit he’d done that to me.”

Now there are two witnesses. The motive is locked in. Two people independently confirmed Richard was leaving everything to TURD. Beau’s face is going to do something — let it.

Alexander’s smoke-break receipt. You then add:

“Sebastian, you said you stepped out for a smoke at 11:30. I saw you come back in at 11:50. That’s a twenty-minute cigarette.”

The room turns to Jaymon.

First accusation vote. Hand out the paper ballots (you have a stack pre-printed). Each player writes one name. You collect them and read them aloud. Sebastian will be the majority pick.

Sebastian breaks. Jaymon reads or improvises his confession. He confesses to the murder. He does *not* implicate Vivi. He protects her. Per his sheet.

End Phase 4. Take a five-minute break. Serve cake. *Make sure everyone has cake before Phase 5 starts.* You want them comfortable, satisfied, thinking it’s over.

Phase 5 — The Architect (15 min)

This is the hardest phase to run. The room thinks the game is over. You’re going to take it from them.

The Christmas-story reveal.

Once the room has cake and is in “wow that was a great game” mode, finish your slice. Set down your fork. Address Daniel or Nicole:

“Hank. (Or: Catherine.) Did Vivi’s bonfire story sound familiar to you?”

Let them pause. Either of them might say *“that was the same one as Christmas dinner”* — which is the ideal. If neither does, you bridge:

“You told me at breakfast this morning that you’d heard it before. At Christmas, you said. Word for word.”

If you have the recordings, play them now. Both, back-to-back. Same story, same beats, same words.

“That was a long story. Twenty minutes long. Sebastian’s smoke break was twenty minutes long.”

The room turns to Sophia.

Final search — Vivi’s bag. Address Sophia directly:

“Vivi. Would you mind if I looked through your overnight bag?”

She’ll refuse — per her sheet. Hank intervenes:

“Open the bag, Vivi.”

Daniel will play this beautifully. Sophia opens the bag. You retrieve Clue 5-1 (the *“Then I’ll have to find another way. — V”* draft letter).

Re-introduce Clue 4-2 if suppressed. If whoever found the *“11:35 — go”* note in Phase 4 chose to suppress it, prompt them now: *“Anyone holding a note in Vivi’s handwriting?”* It must come out.

Second accusation vote. Hand out a second round of ballots. Each player writes a single name. Vivi will be the majority. She is named.

Vivi breaks. Sophia performs the heavy confession. She is not asking forgiveness; she is explaining. Let her have the whole moment. Do not interrupt.

The final narration. Once Sophia finishes, you stand. Pick up Solomon. Walk the family through the whole thing slowly, with full GM omniscience:

“At 2:14 Saturday afternoon, Richard pulled Vivi aside. He told her he was leaving everything — twenty-three motels, sixty million dollars, a parrot, a tortoise rescue — to TURD. He thought she’d be proud. She walked back to the boathouse. She told Sebastian. They drowned for two hours. They came back with a plan.”

“At 11:30, Vivi started a Broadway story she had told before, knowing it would buy her exactly the twenty minutes Sebastian needed. At 11:35, Sebastian stepped out ‘for some air.’ He walked to the dock. He took the loose cleat. He swung once. Richard fell. The cleat went into the lake. The envelope went into Sebastian’s blazer. He returned at 11:50.”

“At 11:55, Vivi walked into the master bathroom, balled up a sticky note that said ‘breathe. it’s done.’ She told herself it was over.”

"It was not over."

Solomon, on cue: **"WHERE'S MY ROOT BEER!"**

End of game.

Closing toast (10 min)

Step out of character. Thank everyone. Take a group photo on the dock. (Cody/Ben in the center.) Give Ben some kind of small physical award — a "Detective of the Year" certificate, a paper crown, anything. He earned it.

Optional: at the closing toast, reveal the bits the players didn't know — Eden knew about TURD since 9 PM Saturday, Cody's photo was the linchpin, the *real* TURD acronym you made up.

Solomon's lines library

You'll need to voice Solomon at minimum five times. Here's the library — pick from these as the room demands. Always shout, never speak:

- **"WHERE'S MY ROOT BEER!"** (the signature — deploy whenever energy dips)
 - **"Don't... don't you talk about her like that..."** (Phase 2 — Hank's gazebo line)
 - **"PRINCESS, PRINCESS, PRINCESS"** (Richard's nickname for Vivi — deploy Phase 3 or 4 to rattle Sophia)
 - **"Sixty MILLION dollars!"** (Phase 4 — after the TURD reveal — comic punctuation)
 - **"TURD! TURD! TURD!"** (Phase 4 — when the room realizes — say it loud, say it proud)
 - **"Step outside for some air"** (Phase 4 — Sebastian's words, screeched back at him)
 - **"Breathe. It's done."** (Phase 5 only — Vivi's words, save this for the very end)
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Accusation handling

Players will accuse early. That's fine. Encourage discussion but do not let a Phase 2 or 3 accusation become a formal vote. Phase 4 has the first official ballot, Phase 5 has the second. Anyone accusing earlier just gets a head start on suspicion.

Players will accuse the wrong person. Also fine. If somebody zeroes in on Hank in Phase 2, the green tweed will look like proof. Let them ride it. Hank's confession breaks the spell.

Players will accuse Alexander. Some chaos goblin will try this. Smile warmly. Say: *"I'm flattered. I'm also not a Whitfield, I have no motive, and I'm the one telling you what's happening. Please vote again."*

A player gets it right early. If somebody correctly fingers Sebastian or Vivi in Phase 3 — fully, with motive — slow them down. *"That's a strong theory. Can you prove it?"* The clues that prove it haven't surfaced yet. Make them wait for the evidence. The game collapses if you confirm a guess before Cody's photo.

Troubleshooting

A player checks out. Bring them in with a direct question to their character. *"Levi — you've been quiet. What did you see Saturday night?"* This forces them back into character and gives them a moment to deliver. Works especially well for Luke.

A player overplays. If Daniel or Sophia are chewing scenery in a way that's stalling the game, you can cut them off in character: *"Mr. Whitfield, I'm going to ask that we move on. The Sheriff is coming."*

The room is too quiet. Solomon. Always Solomon.

Two clues collide in the same search round. Decide which one matters more for that phase's confession. The other can wait until the next discussion.

Somebody finds a clue and refuses to share it during the mandatory share. Press once: *"Are you sure?"* If they still refuse, you publicly disclose it: *"I'll share it for them. They found a small scrap of green tweed in Hank's coat pocket."* They learn the rule for next round.

The murderer's clue gets suppressed. This is *fine*. The Clue Deck has redundancy. Sebastian's ledger (3-10), the dock diagram (3-8), the envelope (4-1), the binoculars (4-3), Cody's photo, Eden's corroboration, the smoke-break receipt, the Christmas story, Vivi's draft letter — there are so many threads that suppressing one or two doesn't break the case. If somebody hoards a critical clue all the way to Phase 5, you reveal it yourself: *"I think someone is sitting on something they ought to share."*

A kid gets uncomfortable. Cody/Ben is 14. If at any point Ben seems overwhelmed by the spotlight, take a five-minute break and check in with him privately. Tell him he can hand the photo over without saying his line if he wants. He decides his level of involvement.

The game runs long. Cut Phase 3's second search if you're behind. The five Sinner confessions are the heart of that phase, not the searching.

The game runs short. Add a 10-minute "free discussion" break between Phase 3 and Phase 4 for snacks. Lets the room catch its breath and theorize.

What success looks like

By the end, your family should have:

- Laughed at TURD at least four times.
- Gaspd twice — once at Cody’s photo, once at the Christmas story.
- Looked at Sophia in a completely new way in Phase 5.
- Heard Solomon scream “**WHERE’S MY ROOT BEER!**” until they cannot stop laughing about it.
- Felt the design — that this was structured, but they made it their own.
- Asked you when you’re running the next one.

— end of GM Guide —